

Post-Colonial Theory



Re-cap of the Cantino Planisphere

- It is remarkable as it focuses not on land masses and cities but on coasts and oceans and links between countries:
- The following link has lots of more detailed images. But its interpretation of these only briefly mentions slavery and does not seem to notice that West Africa had enormous resources:
- <https://smarthistory.org/cantino-planisphere/>

Re-cap on French

Born in Blackness. Africa, Africans and the Making of the Modern World, 1471 to the Second World War

By Howard French (2021)

He argues that we must not ignore the role of Africa in the development of modernity

The point is not simply to “add” Africa in but to invert the current view

To see another **perspective** among many

For example, the Portuguese use cotton from India to buy gold in Africa to use as coinage in Europe (in the 1500s!)

But our maps are all made in a certain way....

Some countries which used to be colonies of Britain –

- Some states of North America until – 1776
- Canada – 1867
- Australia – 1900
- Ireland – 1922
- India and Pakistan – 1947
- Ghana – 1957
- Jamaica – 1962
- Hong Kong – 1997
- Until these dates all the people who lived in these countries were British subjects and were under the authority of the government in London and the Queen (or King).
- Other countries such as Palestine and Iraq were administered by Britain.

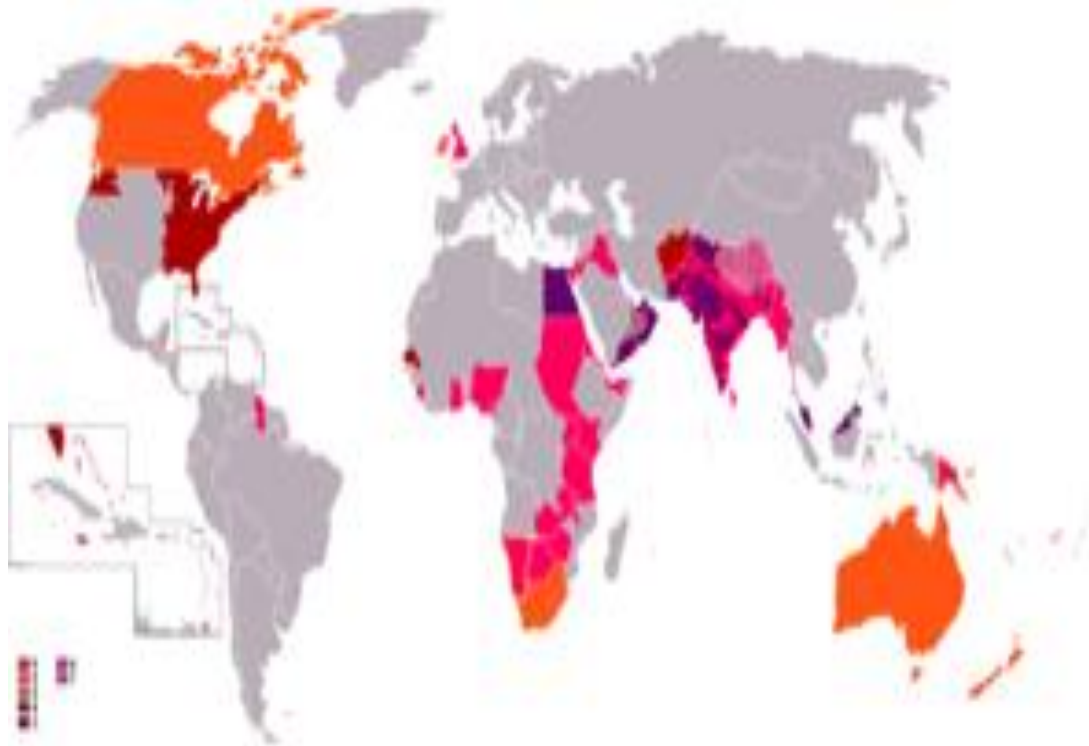
France colonized....

- Much of what is now Vietnam and Cambodia
- Much of North Africa (eg Algeria, Morocco)
- West and Central Africa (eg Ivory Coast, Cameroon, Gabon)
- West Indies (eg Martinique)
- Middle East (eg Syria, Lebanon)

Colonialism

- 3 elements to colonialism:
- The **settlement** of land – where people from one country go and live in another country and claim ownership of that land and often displace the indigenous population
- The **economic** relationship. There is a direct link between capitalism and colonialism which benefits the colonizer.
- The **unequal power relations** whereby colonialism dominates the indigenous population

The British Empire (Around 1924)



Stuart Hall on the West and the Rest

- **The West and Modernity as created in terms of what they are not:**
- **Rational Irrational**
- **Cultured Savage**
- **Mind Body**
- **Progress Tradition**
- **Science Magic**

Said on Orientalism

- **Edward Said (1935-2003):**
- **Born in Jerusalem when it was part of Palestine and when Palestine was a British Mandate (under British control)**
- **Brought up in Egypt, taught in New York**
- **“The relationship between Occident and Orient is a relationship of power, of domination”. Said: [1978] 1995: 89)**



Imagination and fantasy and Writing the Orient

- “The Orient is not only adjacent to Europe; it is also the place of Europe’s greatest and richest and oldest colonies, the source of its civilization and languages...and one of its deepest and most recurring images of the Other.” Said: [1978] 1995: 87)



- **The ‘Orient’ is a construction – it is not just an invention –it is not just made up –but it is a legacy and a result of ways of thinking, acting, studying, trading, and dominating which still have effects today in how people in the West think about and act about people in that region:**
 - **Iraq**
 - **Boundaries of the EU**
 - **Immigration**
 - **Islam**
 - **‘Arabia’**



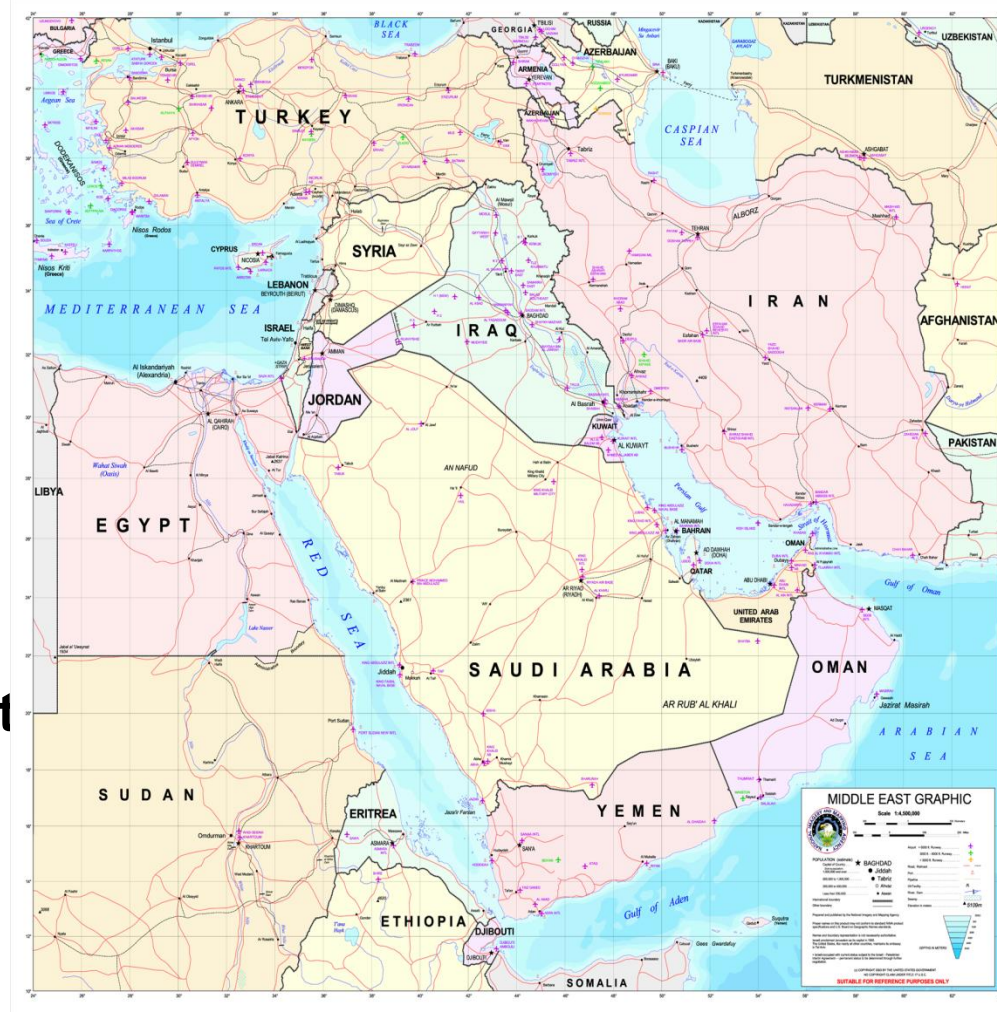
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Constructing (false) binary divisions

“Orientalism is a style of thought based upon an ontological and epistemological distinction made between ‘the Orient’ and ‘the Occident’.” Said: [1978] 1995: 88)

- **“to show that European culture gained in strength and identity by setting itself off against the Orient as a sort of surrogate and even underground self”. Said: [1978] 1995: 89)**



- http://uk.youtube.com/watch?v=qAY_o36paQ0

Stereotypes of the Orient which arise from this:

- **Orient as timeless**
- **Orient as mysterious**
- **“The Orient was almost a European invention, and has been since antiquity a place of romance, exotic beings, haunting memories and landscapes, remarkable experiences”. Said: [1978] 1995: 87)**
- **Orient as feminine – passive, luxurious**
- **Orient as immoral – decadent**



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Common Room (5A.325), Thursday 4 December, 4.30pm - 7pm

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To Read Later

- **All the above legitimate French and British colonialism**
- **“My contention is that without examining Orientalism as a discourse one cannot possibly understand the enormously systematic discipline by which European culture was able to manage - even produce - the Orient politically, sociologically, militarily, ideologically, scientifically, and imaginatively during the post-Enlightenment period.” Said: [1978] 1995: 88-9)**

- **Chandra Mohanty (1955 – present) born in Mumbai:**
- "Under Western Eyes: Feminist Scholarship and Colonial Discourses"
Feminist Review 30, Autumn 1988
- **The notion of 'Third world woman' is an effect of discourse. It does not represent a real empirical group but is produced in Western (and some western feminist) approaches to understanding the world.**



Women as the other of the other:

- “This average third world woman leads an essentially truncated life based on her feminine gender...and being ‘third world’ (read: ignorant, poor, uneducated, tradition-bound, domestic, family-oriented, victimized etc.).” (Mohanty: 1995: 261)





- **“This, I suggest, is in contrast to the (implicit) self-representation of Western women as educated, modern, as having control over their own bodies and sexualities, and the freedom to make their own decisions.”
(Mohanty: 1995: 261)**



- **Mohanty wants to challenge “The assumption of women as an already constituted, coherent group with identical interests and desires, regardless of class, ethnic or racial location or contradictions, implies a notion of gender...which can be applied universally and cross-culturally.” (Mohanty: 1995 261)**

- **Instead, she thinks it is important to theorise the differences within these oppressed groups and not to just assume that all ‘victims’ of colonialism experience colonialism in the same way. And this is especially the case, says Mohanty with reference to male violence – Mohanty says:**
- **“Male violence must be theorized and interpreted *within* specific societies, both in order to understand it better, as well as in order to effectively organize to change it.” (Mohanty: 1995: 262)**

Fanon – on the experience of colonialism

- Frantz Fanon was born in French Antilles in the Caribbean in 1925.
- This was a colony of the French empire. He was educated in Martinique and in Paris and became a doctor and psychiatrist – he was also influenced by philosophy – most notably existentialism (such as that of Sartre). He was one of the first writers to describe and challenge the concepts and practices of colonialism and to argue from the position of the colonized. His main books are –
- *Black Skin, White Masks* (first published in 1952)
- *The Wretched of the Earth* (first published in 1961)



4 crucial points:

- Being an object
- Being a subject
- (Think about Du Bois and also Foucault, perhaps)
- White (men) as the subjects of history.
- The denial of subjectivity to people who have been colonized

- As with Du Bois, the language used by Fanon, reflects the culture/society of the time.
- Next slide...

The experience of colonialism as racism

- **““Look, a Negro!’ It was an external stimulus that flicked over me as I passed by. I made a tight smile.**
- ‘Look, a Negro!’ It was true. It amused me.**
- ‘Look, a Negro!’ The circle was drawing a bit tighter. I made no secret of my amusement.**
- ‘Mama, see the Negro! I’m frightened!’
Frightened! Frightened! Now they were beginning to be afraid of me. I made up my mind to laugh myself to tears, but laughter had become impossible.” (Fanon: [1952] 1995: 323)**

Being an object: The Psychological and Psychic experience and consequences of colonialism.

- **“I am being dissected under white eyes, the only real eyes. I am *fixed*.”
(Fanon: [1952] 1995: 325)**
- **“My body was given back to me sprawled out, distorted, recolored...”
(Fanon: [1952] 1995: 324)**

To Read Later-

Forms of subjectivity

- **“The white world, the only honourable one, barred me from all participation. A man was expected to behave like a man. I was expected to behave like a black man.” (Fanon: [1952] 1995: 324)**
- **“Since the other hesitated to recognise me, there remained only one solution: to make myself known.” (Fanon: [1952] 1995: 324)**

Conclusion:

- **Colonialism was a huge economic, cultural, historical, military and political event which developed from the 1600s and meant that Europe had a huge involvement in Asia, Africa, North and South America.**
- **However, there were differences between all these places and within those groups who were colonized.**
- **How can we develop ways of thinking which address the legacy of colonialism and its place in current society without reducing post-colonial subjects to being the 'same' – they are not just the 'Other' of the West.**
- **Who can speak for whom? Spivak.**

The Mercator Projection



Other ways of seeing the world – (Gall-Peters Projection)

